The British royalty evidently has a weakness for these brands. Princess Diana often took her custom-made Jaguar XJS Cabriolet sports on drives at speeds that threw her bodyguard about. Queen Elizabeth II was reportedly spied behind the wheels of a Land Rover Defender in the Balmoral Palace grounds. Prince Philip shared a similar fascination for the Land Rover Discovery Sport and the Freelander. There is no formal royal or British government event where these brand vehicles are not spotted ferrying dignitaries.

In 1989, Ford had snapped up Jaguar for $2.5 billion in a bid to enter the booming luxury car market dominated mainly by BMW and Mercedes-Benz. Under Ford, it was sardonically termed the ‘English patient’. It was only the memory of its famous old models that kept it afloat. It had ‘antiquated factory and shoddy quality’, commented *Automotive News*. Bill Hayden, who was sent by Ford as the chairman of Jaguar, said, ‘It wasn’t that Jaguar’s quality was bad, it was horrendous … It was a terrible organization making terrible cars’. The joke that did the rounds was that you would not be able to manage with just one Jaguar car; two cars had to be bought because one had to be at the workshop all the time, says Ravi Kant.

In 2000, Ford expanded its base in the UK, buying the Land Rover for $2.75 billion from BMW. It became the world’s second-largest car manufacturer at the time, with Jaguar, Aston Martin, the Lincoln marques and Volvo in its stable. But the grandiose plans of the American giant to become a large European player in the luxury segment soon failed. In 2006 and 2007, it lost more than $15 billion. This was despite an infusion of $10 billion to revive the Jaguar. By 2007, news began to swirl that Ford was planning to hive off all its European luxury models. *The Wall Street Journal Asia* commented that both the brands had become a drain on Ford’s coffers, sharing the ‘baggage of being gas guzzlers in a world shortly to be shaken up by savage new fuel economy rules’.

The article went on to say that ‘during the Ford years of ownership … Jaguar was plagued by stodgy design and a failure to develop new markets’. The Land Rover had tried to right its past wrongs, ‘but the Range Rover and its slightly smaller Discovery sibling’ were ‘chronically overweight’. Unable to achieve a turnaround in Jaguar and Land Rover, Ford became desperate to sell them off.